



Breathe, Screen, Live

Managing Chronic Health Conditions

A practical guide for living well with long-term health conditions

- Understanding chronic conditions and their impact
- Building a management plan that works for you
- Medication, lifestyle, and monitoring essentials
- Mental health and emotional wellbeing
- Navigating South Africa's healthcare system

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What Are Chronic Conditions?

Chronic conditions are long-term health issues that require ongoing management. Unlike acute illnesses that come and go quickly, they persist for months or years.

Common chronic conditions include diabetes, hypertension, asthma, arthritis, heart disease, chronic kidney disease, and depression. Many people live with more than one — known as multimorbidity.

Living with a chronic condition doesn't mean you can't live well. With proper management, most people can lead full, active, and productive lives.

Building Your Healthcare Team

Managing a chronic condition is a team effort. Your healthcare team may include:

- Your primary care doctor or general practitioner — your first point of contact and care coordinator
- Specialists — such as endocrinologists (diabetes), cardiologists (heart), or pulmonologists (lungs)
- Nurses — for monitoring, education, and ongoing support
- Dietitians — for personalised nutrition advice
- Physiotherapists — for exercise and mobility support
- Pharmacists — for medication advice and management
- Mental health professionals — counsellors or psychologists for emotional support

Build a relationship with each team member. Don't be afraid to ask questions, seek second opinions, or request referrals. You are the most important member of your healthcare team.

Medication Management

Many chronic conditions require long-term medication. These tips will help you stay on track:

- Understand what each medication does and why you're taking it
- Take medications at the same time each day — link them to daily habits
- Use a pill organizer or medication reminder app
- Keep a list of all your medications, including dosages and frequency
- Refill prescriptions before you run out — set a reminder
- Never stop medication without consulting your doctor, even if you feel better

- Report side effects to your doctor — there may be alternatives

Monitoring Your Condition

Regular monitoring helps you and your healthcare team track your condition.

- Blood pressure checks — at home and at medical appointments
- Blood sugar monitoring — if you have diabetes
- Weight tracking — important for heart disease and diabetes
- Symptom diaries — note when symptoms occur, their severity, and possible triggers
- Regular blood tests — as recommended by your doctor
- Annual check-ups — comprehensive reviews of your overall health

Nutrition for Chronic Conditions

What you eat has a profound impact on chronic conditions. Key principles:

- Eat plenty of vegetables and fruits — at least 5 portions daily
- Choose whole grains over refined carbohydrates
- Include lean protein sources — fish, chicken, eggs, legumes
- Limit processed foods, sugar, and unhealthy fats
- Reduce salt intake — aim for less than 5g per day
- Stay hydrated — drink 6-8 glasses of water daily
- Eat mindfully — pay attention to hunger and fullness cues

Consider consulting a registered dietitian who can create a personalised eating plan that takes all your conditions and medications into account.

Physical Activity

Exercise is one of the most powerful tools for managing chronic conditions. It improves heart health, blood sugar control, joint function, mood, and sleep quality.

Start where you are. If you've been inactive, begin with 5-10 minutes of gentle activity — a short walk, gentle stretching, or chair exercises. Gradually increase as your fitness improves.

Always check with your doctor before starting a new exercise programme, especially if you have heart disease, poorly controlled diabetes, or joint problems.

Mental Health & Emotional Wellbeing

Living with a chronic condition can take a toll on your mental health. It's normal to feel frustrated, anxious, or depressed at times.

- Talk to someone — family, friends, or a support group
- Consider professional help — counselling or therapy can make a significant difference
- Practice stress management — deep breathing, meditation, or gentle yoga
- Stay connected — isolation can worsen both physical and mental health
- Set realistic goals — celebrate small victories
- Be kind to yourself — some days will be harder than others, and that's okay

Organising Your Healthcare in South Africa

Navigating healthcare in South Africa can be complex:

- Public sector: Chronic conditions are managed at primary healthcare clinics and community health centres. Medications are often available at no cost.
- Private sector: Most medical aid schemes offer chronic disease management programmes. Check with your scheme for condition-specific benefits.
- Medication: Chronic medications can be collected from public clinics or private pharmacies. Some medical aids offer chronic medicine delivery.
- Annual reviews: Even if you feel well, attend annual reviews to screen for complications early.

Preparing for Medical Appointments

Make the most of your time with healthcare providers:

- Bring a list of your current medications (including doses and frequency)
- Write down your questions before the appointment
- Bring your monitoring records (blood pressure log, blood sugar diary, etc.)
- Note any new symptoms or changes since your last visit
- Bring a family member or friend if you need support
- Ask for clarification if you don't understand something

Emergency Signs

Know when to seek immediate medical attention:

- Chest pain, pressure, or discomfort — especially with shortness of breath
- Sudden severe headache, confusion, or trouble speaking
- Difficulty breathing or wheezing that doesn't improve
- Blood sugar above 20 mmol/L or below 3.5 mmol/L
- Blood pressure above 180/120 mmHg
- Signs of stroke: facial drooping, arm weakness, speech difficulty
- Fainting or loss of consciousness

Keep emergency numbers handy: 10177 (ambulance), 112 (mobile emergency), or your local hospital's emergency department.

Disclaimer

This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice. Always consult a qualified healthcare professional for diagnosis, treatment, and management of any health condition. Aliento Health and Dr. Leegale Adonis accept no liability for actions taken based on the information in this guide.

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